new chief at the annual convention in December. The anti-Badal camp has already issued a warning that any bid to reinstate Sukhbir at the helm will not be tolerated. On November 10, the latter had taken to task new Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) chief Harjinder Singh Dhami for arranging a meeting between SAD working president Balwinder Singh Bhunder and Raghubir Singh to resolve the *tankhaiya* issue.

This is now a dual challenge enveloping the Sikh religious as well as political institutions. If the SAD has lost the faith of the *panthic* community in Punjab—the party has just two MLAs now in the 117-seat assembly—Sikh spiritual bodies, too, face integrity issues. As with the SAD, there has been criticism about how only Badal family loyalists are becoming jathedar of the *takht*s or the SGPC chief.

This perception is complicating matters for Sukhbir. As per the *takht* norms, the jathedar can ask Sukhbir to publicly apologise or perform a specific act of penance. In the past, former Akali Dal chiefs and even former Indian president Giani Zail Singh and ex-CM Surjit Singh Barnala have had to apologise and do penance, the first for his role in Operation Blue Star and the latter for Operation Black Thunder. In Sukhbir's case, this involves incidents such as the unresolved blasphemy cases against controversial guru Gurmeet Ram Rahim from 2015, appointments of controversial bureaucrats tainted by allegations of extra-judicial killings of Sikh militants and the mishandling of the Behbal Kalan police firing case, among others. Sukhbir had offered unconditional apologies but it wasn't enough.

Meanwhile, the rebel leaders, led by ex-finance minister Parminder Dhindsa, former SGPC chief Jagir Kaur and others, who call themselves part of the *sudhaar lehar* (reformist wave), are mounting pressure on the takhts to pronounce exemplary *tankha* on Sukhbir. Incidentally, Dhindsa is a *tankhaiya* himself, for seeking electoral benefits from Gurmeet Ram Rahim. The moderates, along with top SAD leaders, want a quicker announcement of the punishment so that Sukhbir is rehabilitated at the earliest. The challenge is that, according to Sikh tenets, Sukhbir can't resume any social or political activity unless he undergoes *tankha*. The rebel factions obviously do not want him extricated from the quagmire. The delay is not helping Sukhbir at all.

The pressure is on the Sikh religious institutions to 'deliver justice' and restore credibility. In the last week of October, even the election for the president of the SGPC—the apex body of all Sikh gurudwaras in Punjab, Himachal and Chandigarh—became a talking point in this context. Dhami, a known Badal loyalist, had defeated rebel Jagir Kaur, but this only reinforced the narrative that the Badals control everything. In mid-October, another controversy erupted after jathedars Raghubir Singh and Harpreet Singh of the Damdami Taksal alleged that their children—settled abroad in the UK and Canada—had been "targeted". They alleged that miscreants had done recces of their places of work and homes. The rebel group is lobbying for Harpreet to be nominated as the new SAD chief. The Sukhbir camp claims the targeting was the handiwork of radical groups trying to pressure the top clergy. Indian security agencies are keeping a close tab on developments.

The SAD's biggest contribution in the past 30 years has been the return of peace in the state, allowing space for the moderates while marginalising the radicals. Any instability in the SAD, or an aversion to its leadership, could help the radicals make a comeback. The international situation, especially India's escalating tensions with Canada over the killing of a Sikh extremist there, adds to the challenge. Canada has one of the biggest overseas Punjabi populations, and also a big radical constituency.

There has been a constant effort by radical groups to capture Sikh institutions, which is a worry for the Indian security establishment. In April last year, radical Sikh preacher Amritpal Singh, now an MP from Khadoor Sahib, had asked Harpreet Singh to convene a Sarbat Khalsa (a deliberative assembly of all factions of the Sikh Khalsa) on Baisakhi day. That didn't happen and Amritpal was subsequently arrested under the National Security Act. Sikh radical groups have got stronger in Canada as well as the UK, with a few of them now in positions of power after winning local elections. Sensing that Sukhbir and the SAD's credibility is at an all-time low, the radicals have also been pushing for the SGPC polls. The last election for the 170-member body happened in 2011. Legal tangles have delayed it since then.

The first casualty of the Sukhbir *tankhaiya* status has been the SAD forsaking the November 20 bypolls for four assembly seats—Gidderbaha, Chabbewal, Barnala and Dera Baba

A SAD TALE



PRABHJOT GILL

- **Sukhbir Badal faces a *tankha* for alleged crimes committed during the SAD regime (2007-17)**
- **Charges include unresolved Gurmeet Rahim blasphemy case, controversial appointments, Behbal Kalan police firing in 2015 (*in pix*)...**
- **Sukhbir's *tankhaiya* status has seen the SAD forsaking the assembly bypolls in solidarity**
- **The future is bleak for the SAD, with just 2 MLAs in assembly, one MP; 11 LS candidates lost deposit**